

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ 8 6
♥ 10 9 7 5
♦ 10
♣ K J 9 7 5 3

♠ A J 9 7 5

♥ J 2

♦ A K 5 3

♣ A Q

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 10 4

♥ A K 8 3

♦ Q J 8 6

♣ 10 6 4

♠ K Q 3 2

♥ Q 6 4

♦ 9 7 4 2

♣ 8 2

West	North	East	South
	1 ♠	Pass	2 ♠
Pass	4 ♠		
All Pass			
4 ♠ by North			

Make a choice. With 20 points you are strong enough to open 2NT. But, with two doubletons you can't really call this a balanced hand. So you should open 1 ♠.

Partner responds 2 ♠.

There should be no doubt about this bid. Partner has at least 6 points so you know there is enough for game. You bid 4 ♠.

North plays 4 ♠. East leads ♥A, ♥K, ♥3 and West follows to all three.

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Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 1 : Total = 5

The 5 loser count isn't actually right because at this point you can dump one of those losers on dummy's ♥Q. The question is: Which one?

You have two chances to set up an extra winner - if the ♦s split 3-2 or if the ♣K is with West. If you discard the ♣Q right now you will be pinning all your hopes on the ♦ split. By discarding a ♦ instead you keep both possibilities alive.

So discard the ♦. Pull trumps with ♠ A J (it takes two rounds) then play ♦A and ♦K. Bad news, West shows out. So now you take your second chance. Enter dummy with a trump and play a ♣, finessing West for the ♣K. Good news, this works. Two chances are better than one.

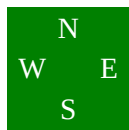
You might have thought it was better to discard the ♣Q rather than a ♦ because the ♣ finesse was only a 50% chance while the chance of a 3-2 ♦ split was much better than that.

The percentages are right but the logic is wrong. If you are going to benefit from a 3-2 ♦ split it is only necessary for you to keep 4 ♦s in **one** of the hands, not both. So the fourth ♦ in your hand was unimportant while the ♣Q gave you an extra shot.

Board 3
East Deals
E-W Vul

♠ 9 8 3
♥ 8 6 5
♦ K Q J 3
♣ A K 4

♠ A K 7 2
♥ 3
♦ 10 8 6 5 2
♣ J 10 8



♠ 6 5
♥ A K Q 7 4
♦ A 9 4
♣ 7 6 3

♠ Q J 10 4
♥ J 10 9 2
♦ 7
♣ Q 9 5 2

West	North	East	South
		1♥	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♥	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by East
of them, at least you have the top 3.

After all that worrying partner bids 4♥ and you pass.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♠Q and the defense plays three high ♠s.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♠Q and the defense plays three high ♠s.

Losers: ♠ 2 : ♥ 0/1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 3/4

If the trumps split 3-2 you are going to make 11 easy tricks.

So you ruff the third ♠ and play ♥A, ♥K. North shows out.

Decide whether to revise the Plan, then

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♠Q and the defense plays three high ♠s.

Don't change plans, the old one was doing fine. Pull one more trump with the ♥Q. That leaves South with ♥J and you with ♥7. Don't panic, just don't lead any more ♥s. Start playing ♦ winners, then ♣ winners. Let South ruff with his ♥J any time he wants to, your ♥7 will then be able to take care of a ♠ return and let you get back to minor suit winners.

When you have pulled some trumps and one defender has the master trump left, it is usually correct to leave it out and start on your side suits. He can ruff with if he wants to, but then you will have trump control again.

This deal is a good example of that principle.

You have an easy 1♥ opening bid.

Partner responds 2♦. What is your next bid?

No matter how much you learn about bidding you will always come across hands which defy you to find anything reasonable to say. This is one of them.

You can't pass. Partner's 2-level response forces you to bid again. You can't raise his bid to 3♦ with only 3-card support. You shouldn't rebid your ♥ suit without 6 of them. And you hate to bid 2NT with your black suit holding. Whenever you get into a situation like this you should admit to yourself that whatever you say is going to be a lie, then try to find the bid that is likely to get you into the least amount of trouble.

In this case that bid is 2♥. Although you only have 5

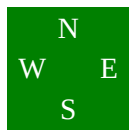
Board 5

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 8 3
 ♥ K Q 10 4
 ♦ J 8
 ♣ 9 7 6 4

♠ Q 7
 ♥ A 8 2
 ♦ 10 9 7 5 2
 ♣ Q J 8



♠ 5 4
 ♥ J 7 3
 ♦ K Q 4 3
 ♣ A 10 5 2

♠ A K J 9 6 2
 ♥ 9 6 5
 ♦ A 6
 ♣ K 3

West	North	East	South
			1 ♠
Pass	1NT	Pass	3 ♠
Pass	4 ♠		
All Pass			
4 ♠ by South			

South plays 4 ♠. West leads the ♥K.

Losers: ♠ 0 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 4

You have one loser to get rid of. Your best approach is to establish a ♣ in dummy to take care of your ♦ loser. You can't pull trumps yet because you need the ♠Q as an entry.

Win the ♥A. Play a ♣ to the ♣K, then another ♣. A defender will probably win this one and they will take two ♥s. But then they must give you the lead. You enter dummy with the ♠Q and dump your ♦6 on the good ♣. Then you pull trumps and claim.

With the ♥ lead you first take the ♥A, then establish a ♣ to discard your ♦ loser, using the ♠Q as an entry.

If the opening lead had been a ♦ you would first take the ♦A, then pull trumps, then establish a ♣ to discard a ♥ loser, using the ♥A as an entry.

If the opening lead had been a ♠ you would pull trumps, then establish a ♣ to discard a red loser on, using the ♥A as an entry.

The same general plan, but with slightly different details, applies with all opening leads.

With 10 points you aren't strong enough to respond at the 2-level, particularly with that weak ♦ suit.

So you bid 1NT. Partner jumps to 3 ♠.

Your 10 points are looking better now that you know partner has at least 16. That puts you at game-going strength.

And your ♠ Q 7 looks better too, knowing that partner has 6 ♠s.

So you bid 4 ♠.

North would play 4 ♠.

Click

South plays 4 ♠. West leads the ♥K.